

GRADE 8 · READING LITERATURE · RL.8.7

The Director's Choices

Compare a script excerpt to a description of its staged production, and evaluate the extent to which specific directorial and acting choices stay faithful to or depart from the written text.

Lesson Map · Passage · Guided · Partner · Independent Practice · Small Group · Answer Key

What You Will Learn Today

Learning Goals

Understand RL.8.7: Compare a script excerpt to a description of its staged production, an...

Read an original passage closely

Support every answer with text evidence

Work through guided, partner, and independent practice

How the Lesson Runs

Warm-up and passage

Guided practice together

Partner discussion

Independent + small-group work

Exit ticket and answer key

Unpacking the Standard

A script is a blueprint; a production is one specific interpretation of it. Directors and actors constantly make choices — about pacing, tone, staging, even cutting or adding lines — that are not required by the script itself. At grade 8, evaluate whether a specific choice serves the script's original meaning, changes it in an interesting way, or works against it.

Modeled Example

A script's stage direction simply says, "She exits." If a director has the actor exit slowly, looking back twice, is that faithful to the script or a departure from it?

It is a departure in specific detail (the script does not require looking back or a slow pace), but it could still be faithful to the script's meaning if the added detail fits the character's established emotional state — departures in staging detail are not automatically unfaithful to the text's meaning.

If a script includes a joke that a director cuts entirely from the final production, what should an evaluation of that choice consider?

It should consider why the joke might have been cut (pacing, tone mismatch, timing) and whether removing it changes the scene's meaning or the audience's understanding of a character, not simply whether a line was removed.

Scene 12, "The Interview" (Original Script)

INT. OFFICE — DAY

MARGUERITE sits across from her interviewer, hands folded.

INTERVIEWER: Tell me about a time you failed.

MARGUERITE: (pause) I don't know that I'd call it failure.

INTERVIEWER: Then what would you call it?

MARGUERITE: A very expensive lesson.

(She almost smiles. The INTERVIEWER writes something down. MARGUERITE watches him write, trying to read it upside down.)

INTERVIEWER: That's all I needed to hear.

MARGUERITE exits.

Director's Notes on the Staged Production

In our production, we kept every line of Scene 12 exactly as written — no cuts, no additions to the dialogue. But we made three staging choices the script doesn't specify. First, we had a full fifteen seconds of silence before Marguerite answers "I don't know that I'd call it failure," much longer than the single-word "(pause)" suggests, to let the audience feel her genuinely searching for an answer rather than performing confidence. Second, we cut the line "trying to read it upside down" from the stage direction — meaning the actor no longer visibly strains to see the interviewer's notes, and instead sits perfectly still, hands still folded, which our director felt made her seem more controlled and less anxious than the original direction implies. Third, we added a full turn back toward the interviewer just before Marguerite exits, a beat not in the script at all, so the audience sees one last flicker of doubt cross her face before she leaves.

Warm-up · Before You Read

1. What explicit dialogue line does Marguerite say in response to "Tell me about a time you failed"?
2. What explicit stage direction does the original script give for how Marguerite responds before her first line?

Guided Practice

3. What is the first staging choice the director's notes describe, and how does it depart from the script's original stage direction?

4. According to the director's notes, what effect was this extended pause meant to create in the audience?

Guided Practice

5. What explicit detail from the original script's stage direction does the production choose to cut entirely?

6. How does cutting that detail change the character's portrayal, according to the director's notes?

Partner Discussion

7. Is the second staging choice (cutting the detail) faithful to the script's dialogue, its stage directions, or neither? Explain.

8. What explicit addition does the production make just before Marguerite exits, according to the third staging choice?

Partner Discussion

9. The original script simply says "MARGUERITE exits." Evaluate whether the added turn-back beat is faithful to or departs from this direction, and explain your reasoning.

Independent Practice

10. Which of the three staging choices most changes an audience's understanding of Marguerite's emotional state, and why?

11. Which of the three choices adds emotional texture without changing any specific fact about Marguerite's character as written?

Independent Practice

12. Evaluate whether the director's choices, taken together, strengthen or weaken the original script's central idea about Marguerite reframing failure as "a very expensive lesson." Support your answer with at least two of the three choices.

13. If a critic argued the production was "unfaithful" to the script simply because it made staging choices not written in the text, how would you respond using evidence from the director's notes?

Independent Practice

14. Choose one staging choice and argue it works against, rather than supports, the script's original meaning. Use specific evidence.

15. Write one sentence evaluating the overall production: does it stay mostly faithful to the script, or does it substantially depart from it? Support your evaluation with evidence from at least two staging choices.

Small-Group Work

16. What explicit claim does the director's notes make about the dialogue at the very start of the notes, before describing any staging choices?

17. Why might the director have chosen to state upfront that the dialogue was kept intact, before listing the staging changes? What does this framing suggest about the production's intention?

Small-Group Work

18. What explicit word does Marguerite's line "A very expensive lesson" replace, based on the interviewer's earlier question about "failure"?

19. How does the third staging choice (the added turn-back and flicker of doubt) relate to Marguerite's reframing of failure as a "lesson" in her dialogue? Does it support or complicate that reframing?

Exit Ticket

20. A reader who has only read the script, not seen the production, would understand Marguerite very differently in at least one way. Identify that difference and explain which of the three staging choices causes it.

Answer Key (1 of 4)

1. "I don't know that I'd call it failure."
2. A single-word direction: "(pause)."
3. The director extended the single "(pause)" into a full fifteen seconds of silence, a much longer and more specific pause than the script's brief direction suggests.
4. It was meant to let the audience feel Marguerite genuinely searching for an answer, rather than performing confidence.
5. The direction that Marguerite watches the interviewer write, "trying to read it upside down."

Answer Key (2 of 4)

6. Without that detail, the actor sits perfectly still with hands folded, which the director felt made Marguerite seem more controlled and less anxious than the original stage direction implies.
7. It is faithful to the script's dialogue, since no spoken lines are cut, but it is a departure from the script's stage directions, since a specific physical action described in the text is removed entirely.
8. A full turn back toward the interviewer, showing one last flicker of doubt on her face, a beat that does not appear anywhere in the original script.
9. It technically departs from the script, since "exits" alone specifies no additional action; however, it could still be considered faithful to the character's established uncertainty (shown through her hesitant first line), since the added doubt is consistent with, rather than contradictory to, who Marguerite seems to be in the written dialogue.
10. The second choice (cutting the "reading upside down" detail) most changes the audience's understanding, because it shifts Marguerite from someone anxiously trying to gather information to someone outwardly composed, altering a specific character trait rather than just adding emotional texture.

Answer Key (3 of 4)

11. The extended pause (the first choice) mainly adds emotional texture — a longer, more visible moment of searching — without changing any concrete fact the script establishes about her, since a pause of some length is already called for.

12. The choices likely strengthen the script's central idea: the extended pause (choice one) makes her eventual composed answer feel more earned, and the added doubtful glance while exiting (choice three) suggests the reframing is not fully resolved for her internally, adding depth to the line rather than undercutting it.

13. This argument oversimplifies faithfulness; the production kept every line of dialogue exactly as written, and its staging choices, while not literally specified in the script, are used to support and deepen the same character and central idea the script establishes, rather than contradict them.

14. Answers vary; a reasonable argument is that cutting the "reading upside down" detail (choice two) removes a moment of visible vulnerability the script specifically included, which could work against the script's apparent interest in showing Marguerite's anxiety beneath her composed answers.

15. Answers vary; require a clear evaluative claim (faithful, departing, or a mix) supported by specific reference to at least two of the three staging choices described in the director's notes.

Answer Key (4 of 4)

16. That every line of Scene 12 was kept exactly as written, with no cuts or additions to the dialogue itself.

17. It suggests the production wants to be understood as fundamentally faithful to the script's words, framing the staging choices as interpretation within that faithfulness rather than as rewriting the scene.

18. It reframes "failure" as a "lesson," showing Marguerite choosing not to accept the interviewer's word for her experience.

19. It likely complicates the reframing, suggesting that despite her composed, reframed answer in dialogue, some genuine doubt or unresolved feeling remains beneath the surface, adding complexity rather than simply supporting or undermining her stated position.

20. A reader of the script alone would likely assume Marguerite is anxiously trying to gather information, based on the "reading upside down" detail; a viewer of the production would instead see her as outwardly composed and controlled, because the second staging choice removes that detail entirely.

Exit Ticket

Answer on a sticky note

Answer the exit-ticket question from today's lesson.

Cite at least one piece of evidence from the passage.

Remember

Name your claim or answer

Quote or cite the evidence

Explain how it supports your answer